INTERVIEW

Kamal Nath, *Former Chief Minister, Madhya Pradesh and President, Madhya Pradesh Congress Committee*

"The biggest problem is no jobs"

Former Madhya Pradesh CM and President, MP Congress Committee **KAMAL NATH** *speaks to India Today Group Editorial Director (Publishing)* **RAJ CHENGAPPA**. *Excerpts:*



▲ **CONVERSATION: ELECTIONS 2023—IS THE CONGRESS READY FOR BATTLE?**

TAKEAWAYS

- "We need to differentiate between freebies and support. A handout to the industry could be a freebie but not support to a poor man"
- "We have to take the organisation to the lower levels. The biggest challenge is to not only have names but people who work. That is what I'm trying to do in MP. We won some tough bypolls as we built an organisation"
- "Nitish Kumar senses the mood of the people and understands the BJP is a burden"
- "The Congress is raising the issue of economic crisis. The people understand everything"

Q. It's been two years and five months since you resigned as CM. Are you missing being in power?

No, I'm not. There was no way I was going to strike a deal. I was being told by MLAs that money was being offered to them. There was no greed for the chair. The government went because it had to. There is always another day.

Q. What is your plan to win back MP?

Our fight is not just with the BJP but with their party organisation. We also need to understand how much politics has changed within a short span of time. Five years ago, 25 per cent of people were on social media, now 95 per cent are. Collecting crowds will not help win elections.

Q. Your party continues to fragment further. Why?

Those who are not going to win are joining the BJP. They can't be stopped.

Q. The Congress won Morena and Gwalior. What does that mean for Jyotiraditya Scindia?

The people in the region have voiced where they stand. The results in Gwalior and Morena are a reflection of changed politics. The BJP should understand the change.

Q. What do you have to say about Shivraj Singh Chouhan's fourth term?

He should not be called for a news channel programme but for an entertainment channel programme.

Q. But what is he doing wrong?

He should stop speaking untruths. He has made 20,000 announcements in 20 years.

Q. You have been in politics for long. Do you see the 2023 elections as the battle of your life?

There is a difference between achievement and fulfilment. For me, the 2023 elections are about fulfilment.

Q. Do you think the opposition parties can come together against the BJP?

I think it will eventually happen. The atmosphere will build up.

Q. What is the vision for MP when you go to the polls?

The biggest problem is unemployment. Every industry that comes in spurns economic activity. Attracting investment will be a priority. Secondly, agriculture is marred by shortages of seed and fertiliser. There is no shortage actually but a problem with the delivery mechanism. ■